

THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

Women cops on bikes? In Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh? Incredulous as it may sound, 'bikewali police didis' are now a common enough sight in this small town of western UP. Women police officers here ride what are locally called 'phantom' bikes, or vehicles that have been modified for policing needs, complete with a hooter, police lights, PA system and more. And it's all thanks to 36-year-old Anukriti Sharma, an IPS officer of the 2020 batch, who is the current Assistant Superintendent of Police (ASP) of the city. Anukriti has taken it upon herself to make the police a more efficient and citizen-friendly force. And the first step towards achieving it, she feels, is by empowering the women officers in the force.

So, female officers under her are given important, and visible, roles. Duty allotments at the police stations are alternated between men and women every week, so that everyone, irrespective of gender, does all kinds of work. Women police officers are encouraged to be on the field, serving summons, carrying out raids, or even making arrests rather than being chained to mundane desk jobs. "Even in paramilitaries," says Anukriti, "women are sent to Naxal-affected areas to address allegations related to human rights violations.... I believe in giving women roles according to their interests and not reducing them to handling medical or female victims and statements under Section 164 of the CrPC. Allowing them to use all resources increases their confidence."

Ask her how many criminals these women cops have nabbed and Anukriti says, "We don't keep tabs on raids conducted genderwise. That defeats the logic of gender parity." But she does go on to reveal, "Last month alone, the Narora thana women police team arrested four male criminals from different locations."

The sight of women policing on phantom bikes inspires confidence in other departments as well. Each of the 25 thanas in Bulandshahr has one such bike. Says Priti Kumari, a female bike rider constable, "Earlier, I'd drive a Scooty at home, but Anukriti ma'am motivated us to drive phantom bikes for serving notices. We do it almost on a daily basis."

Empowering female police officers, Anukriti feels, results in a more efficient, people-friendly, less corrupt, sensitive and more responsive policing. "For far too long, policing has been a male-dominated profession, so much so that it's mostly male complainants who come to thanas and chowkis," she says. "For women, it's still taboo to go to the police station. Hence, since the beginning, I have been trying to make our policing more citizen-centric. Children of any age, elderly or women can walk into our thanas and tell us about their problems. Now, with the help of the government initiative, 'Mission Shakti', we hear women complainants on a daily basis."

Her eventual aim, says Anukriti, is to improve the perception of the police in the public eye. To that end, she regularly holds public meetings and visits schools as well. Little wonder, her work is beginning to get noticed. Especially as a video of the police helping to bring electricity to the house of a 70-year-old woman in the city went viral in June last year. For Anukriti, bringing a smile to everyone's face is a vital part of policing duty. ■

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

- **Under Anukriti, police duties are alternated every week, so that everyone, regardless of gender, gets to do everything**
- **Her aim is to improve perceptions about the police, and make policing more citizen-centric**
- **'Bikewali police didis' are inspiring confidence in others as well**

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